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More funding is approved for Charles sports and wellness center

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Charles County staff present an update to the Charles commissioners during the commissioners meeting on Dec. 9. In the update, they asked for a budget transfer of \$150,000.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

The Charles commissioners approved a budget transfer of \$150,000 on Tuesday for a market and financial feasibility study for the sports and wellness center set to be built in Waldorf.

Maryland appropriated \$125,000 during fiscal 2024 that the county staff decided to use for an economic impact study to understand the financial impact of the center for the present and future of the county, Keli Beaver, director of the Department of Recreation, Parks and Tourism, said. But before they can start the impact study, the Maryland Stadium Authority asked the county to complete a market and financial feasibility study to identify partners that would help build the project.

Maryland Stadium Authority, which helps build, manage and maintain facilities, is open to funding part of the sports and wellness center, Deborah Hall, acting county administrator, said. The total project cost around \$100 million and the county has around \$54 million planned for it.

“A lot of things have been developing behind the scenes with this project that is exceptional,” Hall said. “We are moving very rapidly to try to shore up additional funding.”

Once the feasibility study is complete, it will inform the economic analysis for the Maryland Stadium Authority to complete the impact study, Jim Chandler, director of the Department of Economic Development for Charles County, said.

“These are all pieces of information that help us make business decisions moving forward,” Chandler said.

The county hopes to complete a financial feasibility study by next spring and the project approach by mid-summer 2026. The county is drafting the request for a design proposal for the natatorium.

The project is set to be located at the Sears building at St. Charles Towne Center, Ben Yeckley, planning supervisor of the Department of Recreation, Parks and Tourism, said. As part of the third phase of the project, the county will construct a recreation, entertainment and arts district.

“It’s not just sports and wellness,” Yeckley said. “This is a highlight of looking to do more on a larger scale to draw people here for a longer term.”